IB English A: Language and Literature · Paper 2

The Things They Carried

Tim O'Brien · A Paper 2 guide

Comparative essay preparation
Event bank · Quote bank · Issue arcs across the stories
Dig deeper · Self-test

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How to use this guide

The book is a cycle of twenty-two stories. References take the form **7 (40%)**: story 7, “How to Tell a True War Story”, about 40 per cent of the way through the story, rounded to the nearest 5 per cent. The story list in “At a glance” gives every number and title.

> **Built for Paper 2.** The issue arcs group the stories into four movements: the platoon and the decision to go (1–6), what a true war story is (7–14), coming home and Kiowa’s death (15–19), and the last stories of revenge, breakdown and the dead (20–22).

The examination

Course and paper	IB Diploma English A: Language and Literature, Paper 2: the comparative essay on two literary works studied in the course. Paper 2 is not a set-text exam: the questions are general, they do not name any work, and there are no extracts.
Format	1 hour 45 minutes at both SL and HL. Answer one of four general questions, comparing two of the literary works you have studied. 30 marks; 35% of the final mark at SL and 25% at HL. Check these figures against your current subject guide.
Criteria	A Knowledge, understanding and interpretation (10); B Analysis and evaluation (10); C Focus and organisation (5); D Language (5). Your iSWIM P2 checklist splits B into B1 and B2.
What this means for revision	You will not know the question in advance, so you cannot prepare a single essay. You prepare a small number of moments from each work that you know in detail, grouped by issue, and you rehearse how each work handles those issues differently. That is what the issue arcs, the event bank and the quote bank in this guide are for. Comparison must be structural: every paragraph needs both works.

iSWIM for Paper 2. Use the five guiding questions on every prompt.

i	What is the issue of significance? The concern beneath the prompt's topic word.
S	Why does it matter? The human, social or philosophical stakes.
W	What does each author want you to understand about it?
I	How does each author get you to understand it? Structure, form, characterisation, voice, staging.
M	What does each work position its audience towards, and what does the comparison reveal? The essay-level M comes from the tension between M(A) and M(B).

Write each paragraph with PEACE ACT: Point, Evidence, Analysis, Comparison, Extension, Audience, Context, Tie-back. Characters do not exist: reach through the characters to the choices the writer makes with them.

iSWIM tells you how to plan. Thinking with iSWIM tells you how to think. Your text-type guide tells you what to notice and what to call it.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

The book and the war

The book was published in 1990, twenty years after the narrator's service, and the narrator dates his return to Vietnam twenty years on 19 (5%). It can be read through trauma theory and through the politics of who gets to tell the war; see Dig deeper.

Source: Text

At a glance

Story	Setting	Events	Event titles
Story 1	“The Things They Carried”	E1–E2	The things they carried; Lavender’s death and Cross’s letters
Story 2	“Love”	E3–E4	Love; Love: the promise
Story 3	“Spin”	E5–E6	Spin; Spin: the peace story
Story 4	“On the Rainy River”	E7–E7	On the Rainy River
Story 5	“Enemies”	E8–E9	Enemies and Friends; Enemies: the broken nose
Story 7	“How to Tell a True War Story”	E10–E12	How to Tell a True War Story; Curt Lemon and the baby buffalo; A love story
Story 8	“The Dentist”	E13–E13	The Dentist
Story 9	“Sweetheart of the Song Tra Bong”	E14–E14	Sweetheart of the Song Tra Bong
Story 10	“Stockings”	E15–E15	Stockings
Story 11	“Church”	E16–E16	Church
Story 12	“The Man I Killed”	E17–E17	The Man I Killed
Story 13	“Ambush”	E18–E18	Ambush
Story 14	“Style”	E19–E19	Style
Story 15	“Speaking of Courage”	E20–E20	Speaking of Courage
Story 16	“Notes”	E21–E21	Notes
Story 17	“In the Field”	E22–E23	In the Field; In the Field: blame
Story 18	“Good Form”	E24–E24	Good Form
		E25–E25	

Story 19	“Field Trip”		Field Trip
Story 20	“The Ghost Soldiers”	E26–E26	The Ghost Soldiers
Story 21	“Night Life”	E27–E28	Night Life; Night Life: Rat’s breakdown
Story 22	“The Lives of the Dead”	E29–E30	The Lives of the Dead; The dead talk

Event bank

30 numbered events in order. Read one story for close revision, or E1 to E30 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Story 1

E1 The things they carried 1 (0–25%)

The opening story lists what each man carries, from Martha's letters 1 (0%) to weapons weighed to the ounce, and the intangible loads too 1 (25%).

Why it matters. The catalogue sets the book's method: physical weight stands for moral and emotional weight.

Dig deeper. Why is the first story told in the third person? What effect does that distance have on you?

E2 Lavender's death and Cross's letters 1 (5–90%)

Ted Lavender is shot in the head 1 (5%) while Cross is thinking of Martha, and Cross blames his love 1 (25%). He burns her letters and photographs 1 (90%).

Why it matters. Love is recast as negligence, and command as the duty not to dream.

Dig deeper. Is Cross right to blame his love for Martha? What does burning the letters change?

Story 2

E3 Love 2 (5–30%)

Years later Jimmy Cross visits the narrator; they look at old photographs 2 (5%) and talk about Martha.

Why it matters. The second story already returns to the first: the book circles back on itself.

E4 Love: the promise 2 (100%)

Cross asks the narrator to make him look good in the book 2 (95%) and not to mention something 2 (100%); the narrator promises 2 (100%).

Why it matters. The narrator breaks the promise in the act of telling us about it.

Dig deeper. What does it mean that the book includes the promise it breaks?

Story 3

E5 Spin 3 (0–20%)

A set of fragments: Azar giving a boy with a plastic leg a chocolate bar 3 (0%), and the narrator, a writer now, explaining why he still tells these stories 3 (20%).

Why it matters. The narrator introduces himself as a writer, so the book is a writer remembering, not a soldier reporting.

E6 Spin: the peace story 3 (65%)

Mitchell Sanders tells a story about a soldier who goes back to the war because peace felt so good it hurt 3 (65%); the narrator suspects most of it is made up 3 (65%).

Why it matters. An invented story is offered as the truest account of how the war feels.

Dig deeper. What does the peace story say about peace, and about why men go back to war?

Story 4

E7 On the Rainy River 4 (0–100%)

Drafted in 1968, the narrator drives north towards Canada and spends six days at the Tip Top Lodge with Elroy Berdahl 4 (45%). In a boat a few yards from the Canadian shore he cannot jump, and goes to war out of shame 4 (100%).

Why it matters. The book's idea of courage is inverted at the start: going to war is the cowardly act.

Dig deeper. What is the narrator's definition of courage here? Does he still hold it when he tells the story?

Story 5

E8 Enemies and Friends 5 (0–5%)

Strunk and Jensen fight over a jackknife 5 (5%), then make a pact to kill each other if one is badly wounded. When Strunk loses a leg 6 (25%), he begs Jensen not to do it, and his death later relieves Jensen 6 (100%).

Why it matters. A pair of short stories about promises made in fear and broken in mercy.

Dig deeper. Why is Jensen relieved to hear Strunk has died?

E9 Enemies: the broken nose 5 (90%)

Afraid that Strunk will take revenge, Jensen breaks his own nose with a pistol to even the score 5 (90%).

Why it matters. Fear of an enemy inside the platoon becomes self-injury, foreshadowing Rat Kiley.

Dig deeper. Why does Jensen hurt himself rather than wait to be hurt?

Story 7

E10 How to Tell a True War Story 7 (0–10%)

The story opens by claiming truth 7 (0%) and defines a true war story as one that is never moral 7 (10%).

Why it matters. The book's theory of truth is set out inside a story that keeps revising itself.

Dig deeper. What does he mean when he says true war stories are never about war?

E11 Curt Lemon and the baby buffalo 7 (10–60%)

Curt Lemon is killed by a booby-trapped shell while playing catch 7 (10%); Rat Kiley, grieving, tortures and kills a baby water buffalo 7 (60%). Rat's letter to Lemon's sister goes unanswered 7 (5%).

Why it matters. Grief turns into cruelty, and the obscenity is offered as the mark of truth.

E12 A love story 7 (95%)

The narrator ends by saying the story was a love story 7 (95%) and that all he can do is tell it again.

Why it matters. The story closes by refusing its own genre.

Story 8

E13 The Dentist 8 (75–95%)

Curt Lemon, who acts the tough soldier, faints before the dentist touches him 8 (75%), then returns at night and insists on having a healthy tooth pulled 8 (95%).

Why it matters. A comic story about shame, placed straight after the story of Lemon's death.

Dig deeper. Why does the book tell this after we already know how Lemon died?

Story 9

E14 Sweetheart of the Song Tra Bong 9 (20–80%)

Rat Kiley tells how Mark Fossie brought his girlfriend, Mary Anne, to a medical outpost 9 (20%); she joins the Green Berets on night patrols and is last seen wearing a necklace of human tongues 9 (80%).

Why it matters. A story told at second or third hand, by a teller known to exaggerate, about the war changing a woman as it changes men.

Dig deeper. What turns Mary Anne into a killer? Does it matter that she is a woman? Why does Rat tell it?

Story 10

E15 Stockings 10 (20–55%)

Henry Dobbins wears his girlfriend's pantyhose round his neck on ambush 10 (20%) and believes in their protective power 10 (55%).

Why it matters. Superstition as a way of carrying fear.

Dig deeper. Why does everyone believe in the stockings, even after the girlfriend leaves him?

Story 11

E16 Church 11 (0–80%)

The platoon camps in a pagoda tended by two monks 11 (0%). Dobbins says he once thought of becoming a minister 11 (45%), and Kiowa reflects on using a church as a base.

Why it matters. Kindness and war in the same holy place.

Dig deeper. Where is the irony in soldiers being cared for by monks in a building they are using for war?

Story 12

E17 The Man I Killed 12 (5–25%)

The narrator describes the body of a young man killed by his grenade 12 (5%) 12 (0%) and imagines his life, while Azar mocks and Kiowa comforts.

Why it matters. The repeated inventory of the face replaces any account of feeling.

Dig deeper. Who tells this story? Where do the intimate details of the dead man's life come from?

Story 13

E18 Ambush 13 (0–50%)

When his daughter asks if he has killed anyone, he says no 13 (0%); then he tells the reader how he threw the grenade 13 (15%) and that he did not hate the man 13 (50%).

Why it matters. The same death is told again, with a listener who must be protected from it.

Dig deeper. How does this account differ from "The Man I Killed"? Do you think it is true?

Story 14

E19 Style 14 (5–30%)

In a burned village a girl dances near the bodies of her family 14 (5%); Dobbins tells Azar it does not matter why 14 (30%).

Why it matters. A story about the limits of explanation, and a rebuke to mockery.

Dig deeper. What is this very short story about?

Story 15

E20 Speaking of Courage 15 (0–70%)

Norman Bowker drives round the lake in his home town 15 (0%) with no one to talk to, thinking of the medals he won 15 (25%) and of the Silver Star he did not win, the night Kiowa died 15 (70%).

Why it matters. The war ends, and there is nowhere to tell it.

Dig deeper. This and the title story are the only stories in the third person. Why set them apart?

Story 16

E21 Notes 16 (0%)

The narrator reveals that Bowker asked him to write the story and later hanged himself in a YMCA locker room 16 (0%).

Why it matters. The book comments on its own previous story and admits what it changed.

Dig deeper. Does your view of "Speaking of Courage" change when you learn what was invented?

Story 17

E22 In the Field 17 (0–55%)

The platoon searches the flooded field where Kiowa was killed 17 (0%). Several men blame themselves, Jimmy Cross among them, and a young soldier remembers switching on a flashlight to show Kiowa a photograph 17 (55%).

Why it matters. Blame is shared and misplaced; the death has many authors and no culprit.

E23 In the Field: blame 17 (95%)

Cross reflects that when a man died there had to be blame 17 (95%), and drafts in his head a letter to Kiowa's father 17 (45%).

Why it matters. Blame is shown as a need, not a finding.

Dig deeper. Are the men justified in blaming themselves? How does each handle the guilt?

Story 18

E24 Good Form 18 (20–50%)

The narrator says he did not kill the man on the trail 18 (25%), then that the story is made up 18 (45%), and explains why story-truth can be truer than happening-truth 18 (50%).

Why it matters. The book's central argument, and its most direct challenge to the reader.

Dig deeper. Why does O'Brien cast doubt on the whole book here?

Story 19

E25 Field Trip 19 (10–70%)

Twenty years later the narrator returns to the field with Kathleen 19 (10%) and leaves Kiowa's moccasins in the water 19 (70%).

Why it matters. A ritual of return that settles something private and nothing public.

Dig deeper. Why does he go back, and why take his daughter?

Story 20

E26 The Ghost Soldiers 20 (5–40%)

Shot and nearly dying of shock under an inexperienced medic 20 (5%), the narrator plots revenge on Bobby Jorgenson 20 (40%).

Why it matters. The narrator shows himself at his worst, without excuse.

Dig deeper. This is one of the few stories whose ending we do not know in advance. Why make it suspenseful? How do you judge the narrator here?

Story 21

E27 Night Life 21 (0–95%)

Rat Kiley breaks down and shoots himself in the foot to get out of the war 21 (95%).

Why it matters. The book's best storyteller is undone by the war he talks about.

E28 Night Life: Rat's breakdown 21 (30–95%)

On night marches Rat Kiley begins talking compulsively about bugs 21 (30%), then shoots himself in the foot.

Why it matters. The book's great storyteller loses control of his own story.

Dig deeper. What are the different meanings of "night life" in this story?

Story 22

E29 The Lives of the Dead 22 (0–55%)

The last story joins the dead of the war to Linda, a girl the narrator loved at nine who died of a brain tumour 22 (55%). Stories, he says, can save us 22 (0%).

Why it matters. The book ends with storytelling as a way of keeping the dead alive.

E30 The dead talk 22 (30%)

The narrator explains that in a story the dead talk 22 (30%), as Linda did to him after her death 22 (30%).

Why it matters. Storytelling is presented as a child's way of surviving grief, carried into adult life.

Dig deeper. What does Linda represent for the narrator, and why end the book with her?

Characters

Tim O'Brien (narrator)

A writer, forty-three, who served in the war 3 (20%); the narrator shares the author's name.

- Went to war out of shame 4 (100%).
- Tells and retells the killing of a young man 12 (5%) 18 (25%).
- Defends story-truth 18 (50%).

Arc. From reluctant soldier to the writer who makes the book.

Jimmy Cross

First lieutenant, the platoon's commander.

- Carries Martha's letters 1 (0%).
- Blames his love for Lavender's death and burns the letters 1 (90%).
- Blames himself for Kiowa 17 (30%).

Arc. From dreamer to commander who will not forgive himself.

Kiowa

A devout Baptist who carries a New Testament 1 (10%).

- Comforts the narrator after the killing.
- Dies in the flooded field 15 (70%).
- His moccasins are returned to the field 19 (70%).

Arc. The book's moral centre, and its most mourned death.

Norman Bowker

A soldier who carries a diary 1 (5%).

- Drives round the lake at home 15 (0%).
- Asks the narrator to write his story and later hangs himself 16 (0%).

Arc. The veteran with nowhere to tell it.

Rat Kiley

The medic and the platoon's storyteller.

- Kills the baby buffalo in grief 7 (60%).
- Tells Mary Anne's story 9 (20%).
- Shoots himself in the foot 21 (95%).

Arc. The teller who cannot survive what he tells.

Themes

Each theme is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Truth: story-truth and happening-truth

The book claims truth and admits invention, often in the same paragraph. Its argument is that the emotional truth of a story can matter more than the facts.

Stories 1–6	The first stories offer facts and weights 1 (5%) and a confession 4 (0%). Quotations: Q5, Q8
Stories 7–14	The theory is stated: truth is never moral 7 (10%) and the killing is told twice, from different angles 12 (5%) 13 (15%). Quotations: Q11, Q12, Q13, Q15, Q17, Q20, Q22
Stories 15–19	The narrator denies the killing and the story 18 (45%) and explains story-truth 18 (50%). Quotations: Q27, Q28, Q30
Stories 20–22	The last story claims that stories save 22 (0%). Quotations: –

The whole arc. Truth moves from facts to feelings: by the end, the reader is asked to judge a story by what it makes them feel.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Can two contradictory accounts of the same event both be true? If so, what does "true" mean?
> - If a fabricated story makes you feel what the writer felt, is it more honest than an accurate report that leaves you unmoved?
> - Does your appreciation of a story change when you learn which parts are true and which are invented?
> - What does our discomfort with the paradox of story-truth reveal about what we need stories to do for us?

The burdens they carried

The title story lists weights; the rest of the book weighs guilt, grief and shame. Carrying is the book's image for trauma.

Stories 1–6	The men carry all they can bear 1 (25%); Cross carries Lavender's death 1 (25%). Quotations: Q1, Q2, Q3, Q10
Stories 7–14	The narrator carries the dead man's face 12 (0%). Quotations: Q18, Q19, Q20, Q21
Stories 15–19	Kiowa's death is carried by many who blame themselves 17 (30%). Quotations: Q25, Q26, Q31

Stories 20–22	Rat Kiley breaks under the weight **21 (95%)**. Quotations: Q32, Q33

The whole arc. Some burdens can be set down at the end of a march; the rest are carried into the stories.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Why does the metaphor of carrying fit trauma so well?
> - If setting the burden down is impossible, what does recovery mean?
> - Can a burden that cannot be put into words still be communicated, and if so, how?

Courage, cowardice and shame

The book separates courage from going to war. Shame, not bravery, drives most of its actions.

Stories 1–6	The narrator goes to war because he is ashamed not to **4 (100%)**. Quotations: Q3, Q6, Q9, Q10
Stories 7–14	He kills without hate **13 (50%)**. Quotations: Q16, Q21
Stories 15–19	Bowker fails to win the Silver Star **15 (25%)**; several men claim the blame for Kiowa **17 (30%)**. Quotations: Q25, Q26
Stories 20–22	The narrator's desire for revenge **20 (40%)** shows him without dignity. Quotations: Q32

The whole arc. Courage, in this book, is mostly the willingness to tell the truth about having lacked it.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Is it cowardly to go to a war you believe is wrong because you fear others' judgement?
> - Is the courage to tell the truth about cowardice a kind of courage?

Storytelling as survival

Stories are how the narrator survives, and how he distorts. The book is about its own making.

Stories 1–6	The narrator introduces himself as a writer **3 (20%)**. Quotations: Q4, Q5, Q7, Q8
Stories 7–14	A story renames itself **7 (95%)**. Quotations: Q12, Q14, Q15
Stories 15–19	He reveals that "Speaking of Courage" was written at Bowker's request **16 (0%)** and says why stories exist **18 (45%)**. Quotations: Q28, Q29, Q30
	Stories keep the dead alive **22 (0%)**.

Stories 20–22	Quotations: Q34, Q35, Q36, Q38

The whole arc. The book ends by claiming for fiction the power that the war denied to every other kind of telling.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - If telling a story changes the experience, does narration heal or harm the teller?
> - What is lost when experience is turned into narrative, and is it worth the cost?
> - Can storytelling be both a tool of healing and a mechanism of distortion, and must we accept both?

Memory, silence and coming home

The war continues after it ends, in memory and in the silence of home.

Stories 1–6	Old friends meet over photographs **2 (5%)**. Quotations: Q6, Q7
Stories 7–14	Kathleen's question forces a choice between truth and protection **13 (0%)**. Quotations: –
Stories 15–19	Bowker has nowhere to go and no one to tell **15 (0%)**; the narrator returns to the field **19 (70%)**. Quotations: Q23, Q24, Q29, Q31
Stories 20–22	Memory reaches back to childhood **22 (55%)**. Quotations: Q34, Q36, Q37, Q38

The whole arc. The book suggests that a society which cannot hear its veterans leaves them driving in circles.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - What does it cost a society when it cannot fit its veterans' experience into a shared story?
> - When a nation builds its memory of a war through monuments, anniversaries and official histories, whose experience is preserved and whose is erased?
> - Is Bowker's silence a personal failure or a social one, and does the answer change what we owe veterans?

Gender and the war

Women are mostly absent, idealised, or told about. The one woman who goes to the war becomes its most frightening figure.

Stories 1–6	Martha is an idea Cross carries **1 (0%)**. Quotations: –
Stories 7–14	Mary Anne is transformed by the war **9 (80%)**; Rat's letter to Lemon's sister goes unanswered **7 (5%)**. Quotations: Q17

Stories 15–19	The narrator protects his daughter from the truth 13 (0%). Quotations: –
Stories 20–22	Linda is remembered as the first love and the first death 22 (55%). Quotations: –

The whole arc. The book questions the idea that war is a male experience women cannot understand, while largely telling it through men.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Is Mary Anne's story about women and war, or about the men who tell it?

Theme and story grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that theme's arc.

Theme	Stories 1–6	Stories 7–14	Stories 15–19	Stories 20–22
Truth: story-truth and happening-truth	Q5, Q8	Q11, Q12, Q13, Q15, Q17, Q20, Q22	Q27, Q28, Q30	
The burdens they carried	Q1, Q2, Q3, Q10	Q18, Q19, Q20, Q21	Q25, Q26, Q31	Q32, Q33
Courage, cowardice and shame	Q3, Q6, Q9, Q10	Q16, Q21	Q25, Q26	Q32
Storytelling as survival	Q4, Q5, Q7, Q8	Q12, Q14, Q15	Q28, Q29, Q30	Q34, Q35, Q36, Q38
Memory, silence and coming home	Q6, Q7		Q23, Q24, Q29, Q31	Q34, Q36, Q37, Q38
Gender and the war		Q17		

O’Brien’s methods

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

A story cycle

Twenty-two stories, some a page long, that circle the same events; Kiowa’s death is reached through “Speaking of Courage”, “Notes”, “In the Field” and “Field Trip” 15 (70%) 19 (70%).

Metafiction

The book comments on its own stories 16 (0%) and admits invention 18 (45%).

The author-narrator

The narrator has the author’s name and profession 3 (20%), which makes every admission of invention more unsettling.

Lists and repetition

The title story’s catalogue 1 (25%) and the repeated description of the dead man’s face 12 (0%).

Direct address

The narrator speaks to the reader 18 (45%).

Dig deeper

The surface overview is in the event bank and issue arcs. These sections go further: into trauma and memory, the politics of who tells the war, the several Tims, the reader's part, and the questions the book raises. Every claim about the book is referenced; critical readings are offered for evaluation.

Trauma and memory

On the surface. The book jumps about in time.

Cathy Caruth describes of trauma as an experience that resists linear narrative and returns involuntarily, and Freud's distinction between mourning and melancholia. The killing on the trail is told several times with shifting details 12 (5%) 13 (15%) 18 (25%): the repetition is the shape of the wound.

The last story links the war dead to Linda 22 (55%), and claims that stories can bring them back 22 (0%). This can be read, with Freud, as melancholia, a refusal to let the dead go.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Is the book's structure a description of trauma, or a way of managing it?
> - Does keeping the dead alive in stories help the living?

Power and narrative authority

On the surface. The soldiers tell stories about the war.

Michel Foucault argues that power and knowledge produce each other, so that institutions decide what counts as true. It could be argued that the book sets the soldiers' stories against the authorised stories of the war: Lemon's death is told in grotesque detail 7 (10%), not as heroic sacrifice, and Bowker has medals 15 (25%) but no audience.

Linda Hutcheon's term historiographic metafiction describes fiction that questions how history is written by drawing attention to its own making. O'Brien admits that much of the book is invented 18 (45%), which can be read as resistance to any single official account.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Whose story of the war does the book refuse to tell?
> - Is admitting invention a way of claiming more authority, or giving it up?

Violence, masculinity and shame

On the surface. The soldiers act tough.

Klaus Theweleit's work on soldierly masculinity argues that violence can mask fear of vulnerability. Lemon's tooth 8 (95%), Rat's buffalo 7 (60%) and Jensen's nose 5 (90%) can be read as pain inflicted to manage shame.

Mary Anne's transformation 9 (80%) tests the idea that this is a male experience: the war remakes her as it remakes the men.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Is the violence in these stories about the enemy, or about the men themselves?

Narrative identity and the autobiographical pact

On the surface. The narrator is the author.

Philippe Lejeune's autobiographical pact is the reader's assumption that author, narrator and subject are one person telling the truth. O'Brien keeps the first clause, his own name and profession 3 (20%), and breaks the second 18 (45%).

Paul Ricoeur argues that selfhood is built through the stories we tell; the last story shows the narrator making himself out of stories since childhood 22 (30%). Patricia Waugh's definition of metafiction, writing that draws attention to its own status as an artifact, fits the whole cycle.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - What is gained, and what lost, when an author breaks the autobiographical pact?

Many voices: Kiowa's death

On the surface. Kiowa dies in a field.

Mikhail Bakhtin's idea of polyphony, many independent voices that do not resolve into one, describes how Kiowa's death is told: through Bowker's memory 15 (70%), the narrator's note 16 (0%), the search and the blame 17 (95%), and the return 19 (70%). No single account is complete.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Who is to blame for Kiowa's death, according to each telling?

National myth and memory

On the surface. The war ended twenty years ago.

Benedict Anderson calls nations "imagined communities" held together by shared stories and selective memory. It could be argued that Bowker's circling of the lake 15 (0%) shows a veteran with no place in the national story, and that the book's many voices argue for a memory that includes what does not fit.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - What happens to the individual who carries a story the collective narrative has no room for?
> - What does it cost a society when it cannot fit its veterans' experiences into a shared story?

Who owns the story

On the surface. The book is a soldier's memoir.

It could be argued that four stories compete: the military's, the government's, the protest movement's and the veteran's. None can hold what happened. Bowker has a list of medals 15 (25%) but no listener, and no place to go 15 (0%).

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - When an individual's experience is taken into an institutional story, what happens to the parts that do not fit?
> - Is there any framework for understanding a war that does not distort the soldier's truth?

The several Tims

On the surface. The narrator is Tim O'Brien.

It is useful to distinguish the author, the narrator and the character "Tim", who share a name but not every experience. The narrator gives himself a daughter, Kathleen 13 (0%), and then tells the reader that much of the book is made up 18 (45%). The effect is that no statement in the book can be taken as simple fact.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why give the narrator the author's own name if the stories are invented?

The reader as participant

On the surface. The reader is told a story.

O'Brien addresses the reader directly 18 (45%) and then denies the facts he has given. It could be argued that the reader's wish to know what "really" happened is itself the problem the book is examining.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why do we need stories to be either true or false?
> - If the reader's desire for a factual answer mirrors an institution's demand for a controllable story, does reading become a form of complicity?
> - Can a text that admits its own invention still change what you believe?

Issues of significance

On the surface. Six issues for discussion or for planning a Paper 2 comparison. Each opens with a framing statement, followed by its discussion questions.

1. Story-truth and happening-truth. O'Brien tells you he killed a man 13 (15%). Then he tells you he did not 18 (25%). Then he tells you both answers are true. He is not confused. He is making an argument. Can two

contradictory accounts of the same event both be true, and if so, what does "true" mean? If a fabricated story makes you feel what the writer felt, is it more honest than an accurate report that leaves you unmoved? What does our discomfort with this paradox reveal about what we need stories to do for us?

2. The weight of what cannot be set down. The soldiers carry ammunition, rations, photographs, drugs, guilt, shame, and the knowledge that they took part in things they cannot undo 1 (25%). Some of these burdens have no weight; some weigh more than anything. What is the relationship between physical weight and moral weight, and why does the metaphor of carrying feel so accurate for trauma? Can a burden that cannot be put into words still be communicated, and if so, how? If carrying is the condition and setting down is impossible, what does that imply about recovery?

3. Narrative as survival and betrayal. Stories can save us, O'Brien writes 22 (0%). But stories also reshape, select, distort and replace. The same mechanism that makes survival possible makes faithful representation impossible. If telling a story changes the experience it describes, does narration help or harm the teller? Can storytelling be both a tool of healing and a mechanism of distortion, and must we accept both? What is lost when traumatic experience is turned into narrative, and is what is gained worth the cost?

4. Who owns the story. The military tells one story, the government another, the anti-war movement a third, the veteran a fourth. None of them can accommodate what actually happened. When an individual's experience is taken into an institutional story, whether patriotic, strategic or protest, what happens to the parts that do not fit? If every available framework for understanding war distorts the soldier's truth, is there one that does not? What does it cost a society when it cannot fit its veterans' experiences into a shared story?

5. The reader as participant. O'Brien addresses you directly 18 (45%). He tells you he invented the story 18 (45%). Then he tells you it is true. Your desire to know which it really is: that desire is the problem. Why do we need stories to be either true or false, and what is at stake in the demand for certainty? If the reader's desire for a factual answer mirrors an institution's demand for a controllable story, does reading itself become a form of complicity? Can a text that openly admits its own invention still change what you believe, and what does that reveal about how belief works?

6. National memory and individual silence. Norman Bowker drives endlessly round a lake 15 (0%) because there is nowhere to talk about it 15 (0%). The "it" is not only his trauma; it is a national failure to make room for his story. When a nation builds its memory of a war through monuments, anniversaries and official histories, whose experience is preserved and whose is erased? What happens to the individual who carries a story the collective narrative has no room for? Is Bowker's silence a personal failure or a social one, and does the answer change what we owe veterans?

Questions on the whole book

On the surface. Use these after reading the cycle.

Why do you think O'Brien wrote this book? What is the effect of constantly reminding the reader that the stories are not true? How do you judge the book as a whole?

Quote bank

38 quotations in order, each checked against the text.

Story 1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	1 (5%)	“The things they carried were largely determined by necessity” The flat inventory voice the story will undercut. The burdens they carried
Q2	1 (25%)	“They carried all they could bear” Physical load and emotional load in one sentence. The burdens they carried
Q3	1 (25%)	“now Ted Lavender was dead because he loved her so much” Cross converts love into guilt. The burdens they carried · Courage

Story 2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q4	2 (100%)	“Don't mention anything about” A promise the book records and breaks. Storytelling as survival

Story 3

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q5	3 (20%)	“I'm forty-three years old, and a writer now” The narrator places himself after the war, as a writer. Storytelling as survival · Truth
Q6	3 (65%)	“All that peace, man, it felt so good it hurt. I want to hurt it back.” The paradox of peace for the soldier. Memory · Courage
Q7	3 (95%)	“Stories are for joining the past to the future” Storytelling as a bridge across time. Storytelling as survival · Memory

Story 4

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q8	4 (0%)	“This is one story I've never told before” A confession that frames the book’s first long story. Truth · Storytelling as survival
Q9	4 (100%)	“I was a coward. I went to the war.” Courage inverted in two sentences. Courage

Story 5

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q10	5 (90%)	“used it like a hammer to break his own nose” Self-injury as a way of settling fear. Courage · The burdens they carried

Story 7

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q11	7 (0%)	“This is true.” A claim the story will complicate. Truth
Q12	7 (10%)	“A true war story is never moral” Truth defined against moral lessons. Truth · Storytelling as survival
Q13	7 (10%)	“You can tell a true war story if it embarrasses you” Embarrassment as a test of truth. Truth
Q14	7 (95%)	“It wasn't a war story. It was a love story.” The story renames itself at the end. Storytelling as survival
Q15	7 (100%)	“It's about sunlight” A true war story is about something other than war. Truth · Storytelling as survival

Story 8

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note

Q16	8 (95%)	“yanked out a perfectly good tooth” Shame cured by needless pain. Courage

Story 9

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q17	9 (80%)	“a necklace of human tongues” The image that ends Mary Anne’s transformation, told third-hand. Gender and the war · Truth

Story 10

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q18	10 (55%)	“the protective power of the stockings” Superstition as armour. The burdens they carried

Story 12

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q19	12 (0%)	“his other eye was a star-shaped hole” The precise detail that returns again and again. The burdens they carried
Q20	12 (5%)	“almost dainty young man” Gentle adjectives for a body he has made. Truth · The burdens they carried

Story 13

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q21	13 (50%)	“I did not hate the young man” The act stripped of motive. Courage · The burdens they carried

Story 14

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note

Q22	14 (30%)	“it didn't matter why, she just was” A refusal to explain. Truth

Story 15

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q23	15 (0%)	“there was no place in particular to go” The veteran’s problem: nowhere to tell it. Memory

Story 16

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q24	16 (0%)	“three years later hanged himself” A fact delivered in a subordinate clause. Memory

Story 17

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q25	17 (30%)	“It wasn't the LT's fault” Blame offered and refused in the field. The burdens they carried Courage
Q26	17 (95%)	“When a man died, there had to be blame” Blame as a need. The burdens they carried Courage

Story 18

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q27	18 (25%)	“I did not kill him” A denial that contradicts the earlier stories. Truth
Q28	18 (45%)	“Even that story is made up.” The narrator withdraws what he has just said. Truth Storytelling as survival
Q29	18 (45%)	“I want you to feel what I felt.” The purpose of story-truth. Storytelling as survival Memory

Q30	18 (50%)	“story-truth is truer sometimes than happening-truth” The book’s central claim. Truth · Storytelling as survival

Story 19

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q31	19 (70%)	“Inside were Kiowa's old moccasins” A private ritual of return. Memory · The burdens they carried

Story 20

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q32	20 (40%)	“the need for revenge kept eating at me” The narrator at his least admirable. Courage · The burdens they carried

Story 21

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q33	21 (95%)	“put a round through his foot” Rat Kiley’s escape by self-injury. The burdens they carried

Story 22

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q34	22 (0%)	“stories can save us” The final claim for fiction. Storytelling as survival · Memory
Q35	22 (25%)	“you dream it as you tell it” Telling as dreaming. Storytelling as survival
Q36	22 (30%)	“Timmy, stop crying” The dead speak in stories. Memory · Storytelling as survival
Q37	22 (55%)	“It was a brain tumor” The first death the narrator knew, told as plainly as the war. Memory

Q38	22 (100%)	“skimming across the surface of my own history” The book’s last image: memory as skating. Memory · Storytelling as survival

Self-test

7 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **What does Jimmy Cross burn?**
   Kiowa's moccasins / Maps / Martha's letters and photographs / Ted Lavender's diary
2. **Where does the narrator stay before deciding to go to war?**
   A YMCA / Fort Dix / His parents' house / The Tip Top Lodge, with Elroy Berdahl
3. **How does Curt Lemon die?**
   A booby-trapped shell while playing catch / Drowning / Friendly fire / Sniper fire
4. **What does Mary Anne wear at the end of her story?**
   A Green Beret uniform / A culotte / A necklace of human tongues / Pantyhose
5. **Where does Norman Bowker drive?**
   Across Canada / Round a lake in his home town / To the VA hospital / To the narrator's house
6. **What does the narrator leave in the field?**
   A New Testament / A photograph of Martha / His medals / Kiowa's moccasins
7. **Who is Linda?**
   A girl the narrator loved at nine, who died of a brain tumour / A nurse / Cross's fiancée / Kiowa's sister

Answers

1. Martha's letters and photographs 1 (90%)
2. The Tip Top Lodge, with Elroy Berdahl 4 (45%)
3. A booby-trapped shell while playing catch 7 (10%)
4. A necklace of human tongues 9 (80%)
5. Round a lake in his home town 15 (0%)
6. Kiowa's moccasins 19 (70%)
7. A girl the narrator loved at nine, who died of a brain tumour 22 (55%)

Sources

- Tim O'Brien, *The Things They Carried* (1990).
- The iSWIM Primer on issues of significance, the TTTC reading notes and book notes, and the chapter questions.
- The iSWIM framework for Paper 2.